

The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

Manchester picks a mayor while the mayor it lost curbs his own release scheme

Greater Manchester replaced its mayor this week, and the man it lost curbed his own government's early-release scheme – both decided, in the summer manner of this administration, entirely outside the chamber. On Thursday 30 July some 2,142,779 electors were entitled to choose Andy Burnham's successor, the largest by-election electorate this country has ever assembled; 538,659 of them took part, a turnout of 25.14 per cent, and after a count of roughly fifteen hours Bev Craig, leader of Manchester City

Council, was declared at Co-op Live on Friday night – 47.1 per cent on first preferences, 66.3 in the runoff against Reform UK's Sian Astley, the Conservative candidate fifth on 7.7. Then on Tuesday the Prime Minister she succeeds announced, by press release, that rape, serious child sexual offences and grooming offences are barred from the Sentencing Act's early-release changes: roughly 5,000 prisoners now release across ten months instead of 6,000 in September, the start pushed to 1 October, prisons standing at 98 per cent. The exclu-

sions do not reach manslaughter, so two of PC Andrew Harper's killers remain eligible – his widow called it an utter betrayal, and the new Justice Secretary, Alex Norris, said he was deeply sorry while defending the line he drew. The Commons that would ordinarily test all of this returns on 1 September; until then the score is kept in writing, where 126 answers arrived this week, twelve of them explaining what the Department for Education does with artificial intelligence, and one what Great British Railways intends by way of biometrics at stations.

GREATER MANCHESTER ELECTS BEV CRAIG

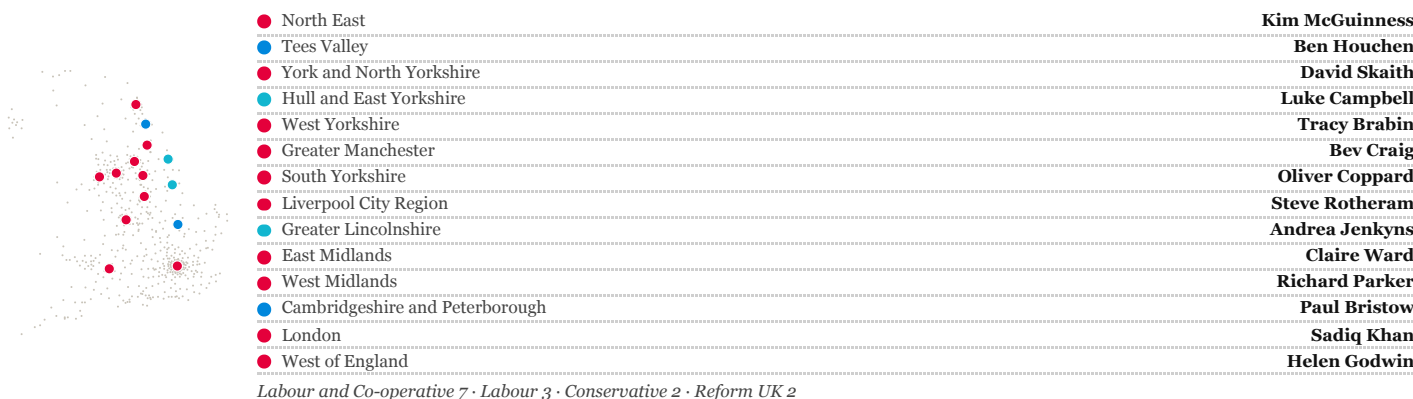
Thursday 30 July, declared Friday 31 July. Seven candidates stood for the mayoralty Andy Burnham vacated. Bev Craig took 251,449 first preferences and won the runoff with 66.3% against Sian Astley of Reform UK. The count ran about fifteen hours and the declaration came at Co-op Live. She promised to fight for a better life for all of Greater Manchester.

RAPE AND GROOMING OFFENCES BARRED FROM EARLY RELEASE

Tuesday 4 August. The Prime Minister and the new Justice Secretary Alex Norris excluded rape, serious child sexual offences and grooming offences from the Sentencing Act changes. About 5,000 prisoners will now release over ten months instead of about 6,000 in September. The start moves to 1 October and prisons stand at 98% of capacity.

THE MAYORS OF ENGLAND, AS THEY STAND TONIGHT

Fourteen directly elected regional mayoralties after Thursday's by-election. Ten are Labour or Labour and Co-operative, two Conservative, two Reform UK.



THE WEEK IN BRIEF

The exclusions stop short of manslaughter, Tuesday 4 August. Two of the men who killed PC Andrew Harper stay eligible for earlier release because manslaughter was not added to the list. His widow Lissie Harper called the decision an utter betrayal. Alex Norris said he was deeply sorry. The shadow justice secretary Nick Timothy called the wider change a victory for victims that does not go far enough.

126 written answers arrive during recess, Across the window. Nobody could table a question and ministers answered anyway. The Department for Education sent 58 replies of which twelve concern its use of artificial intelligence. Transport sent 45 including one on biometric technology at railway stations. Nine covered childcare fees.

When Parliament comes back, Tuesday 1 September. The summer recess runs to 31 August. Every decision in this issue was made by declaration or press release. The first chance to question any of it from the floor of either House comes when Members of Parliament return.

THE FEATURE

A justice climbdown conducted entirely by press release

The early-release scheme was the last government's answer to prisons at 98% of capacity. The new Prime Minister paused it within days of taking office and this week cut it back. Offenders convicted of rape, serious child sexual offences and grooming offences will serve their full custodial term. Those re-

leased early will be fewer and slower, about 5,000 over ten months rather than 6,000 in one. More than 18,000 offenders were already excluded. The change arrived with £10 million for victim support and £700 million for probation with 1,300 more officers. None of it was announced to

Parliament because Parliament is not sitting. The victims' commissioner says exclusions alone cannot guarantee safety. The domestic abuse commissioner says the list leaves abusers inside the scheme. The first minister to answer for the balance struck will do so in September.

THE RECORD

Every figure checked against the official Parliament record. Compiled from the Official Report, the written question record and the division lists, and rendered to one sheet for the week.